Design Collaboration in the Age of AI

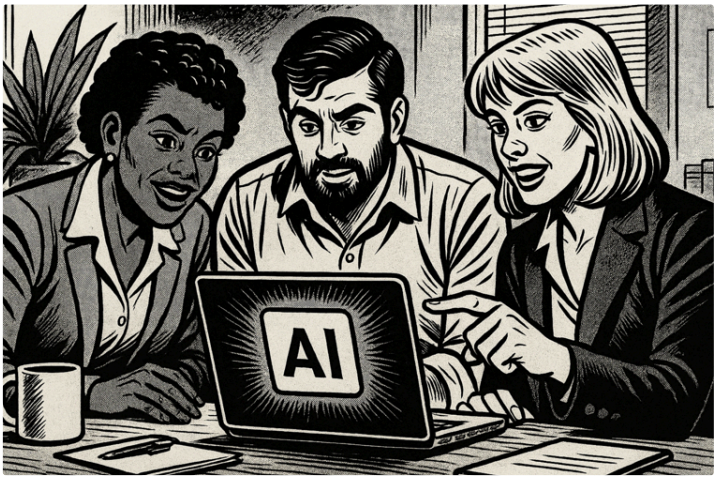

Image: An AI-generated illustration showcasing cross-functional collaboration.

Intro

Like many of you, my social media feeds have been flooded with AI content. At the start of the year, I was still firmly in the skeptical (read: *deeply cynical*) camp. AI was being marketed as the ultimate fix for everything—from writing poems to solving world hunger—and I wasn't buying it.

But I figured: if I could take the time to really understand how this tech was evolving—and witness actual, relevant use cases in my daily design work—maybe I'd be better equipped to hold a nuanced conversation about the real dangers of machine overlords. Fortunately, a colleague provided a small push, allowing us to experiment with new design flows on a small scale. This article shares some of the insights from that experience.

The Current State of AI

Since last year, the pace of development across different language models has been mind-boggling. I couldn't keep track. To me, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini—they were all just competing flavors of the same thing. I was still thinking in "old software" terms.

Then, it clicked. With the recent emergence of "vibe coding" tools like Lovable, Bolt, V0, UX Pilot and more advanced integration with AI in Cursor, Claude Code (and MCP [Model Context Protocol]), among many others, it's clear that the true power of AI lies not in writing haikus or summarizing WWII, but in its ability for *doing actual work*.

It's not about replacing engineers, PMs or designers. It's about boosting collaboration in ways that remove some of the friction in our current workflows. I witnessed a case of some of my colleagues and team members exploring AI in a real-life collaboration opportunity, and I wanted to share it with you.

The Problem

As designers, our impact goes far beyond the visual appeal of our screens. But let's face it: most product improvements eventually touch the UI, which means we end up deep in Figma land.

And that's where things get tricky.

Our current process leans heavily on Figma—not just for design, but for prototyping, testing, and handoff. And while Figma is a powerful tool, it's not exactly the most inclusive or collaborative space, especially for folks who don't live in it daily.

This means a lot of the actual problem-solving happens in silos. PMs and engineers have to catch up via presentations, comments, and long meetings. The result? Endless feedback loops, slow decisions, and plenty of room for misunderstanding.

In the section below, @Siddhant Mittal will share how he used AI to quickly design initial mock-ups for a new feature, Category Recommendations.

A New Approach (with a Little Help from AI)

Hi, I'm Siddhant, and I'm the Product Manager for the Category Management team within the Commercial tribe. One of the challenges we face in Product teams (I am sure you do too 🫠) is Design capacity. Imagine the last time you wanted to dig deep into a topic, and your design buddy had all the availability? 😅

I was facing the same challenge recently when I was working on the new feature—**Category Recommendations**—in the Jobs flow in Catalog. The designer supporting our team was already stretched thin, so instead of waiting, I decided to get creative. I remember reading a post on LinkedIn that spoke about different AI tools that PMs should be using.

So what did I do? I thought of giving Lovable a try! Apparently one could use this tool to create mockups and wireframes. So I went to the website, quickly signed up and started exploring. To begin with, I took a screenshot from the Catalog's UI and started prompting the tool with different ways to incorporate the new feature. The visuals weren't perfect—UI components didn't fully match our design system—but they were good enough for us to get a head start on this topic!

@Santiago Sardi , the designer, and I were able to sit down with a working strawman. We clicked through, explored options, and aligned fast. No Figma files, no endless comment threads—just a collaborative session with a shared starting point.

After a few iterations, Santi translated the agreed direction into Figma. In the future, with design systems plugged into AI tools, even that step might not be needed. Even more exciting: the AI-generated prototype was React-based, meaning engineers could potentially jump straight into implementation, and we would be able to spend more time on the ideation and testing work.

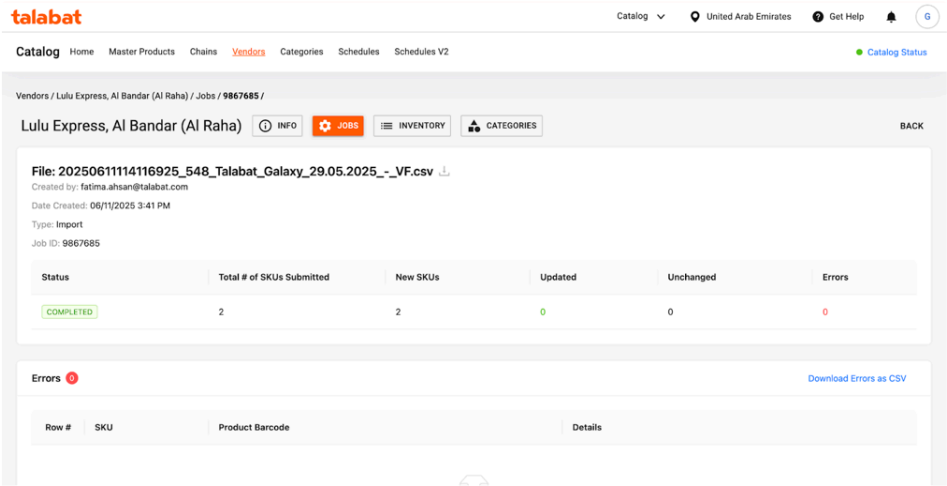

Image: Current Catalog UI

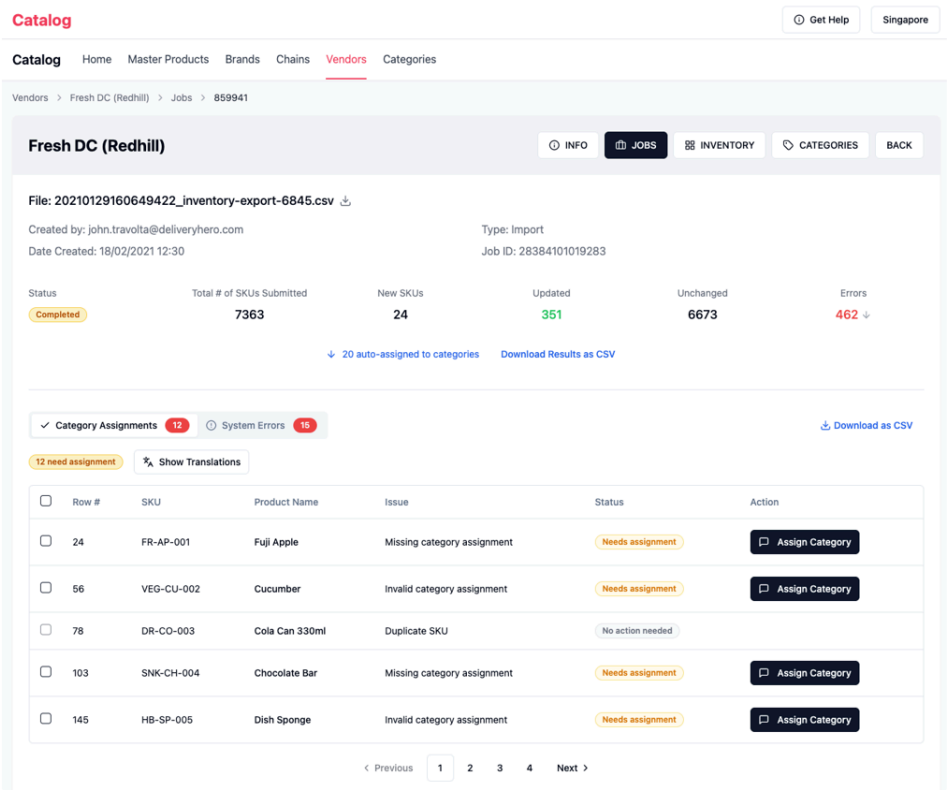

Image: Catalog UI created in Lovable with changes (it modified parts of the UI we didn't even ask it to 🙈)

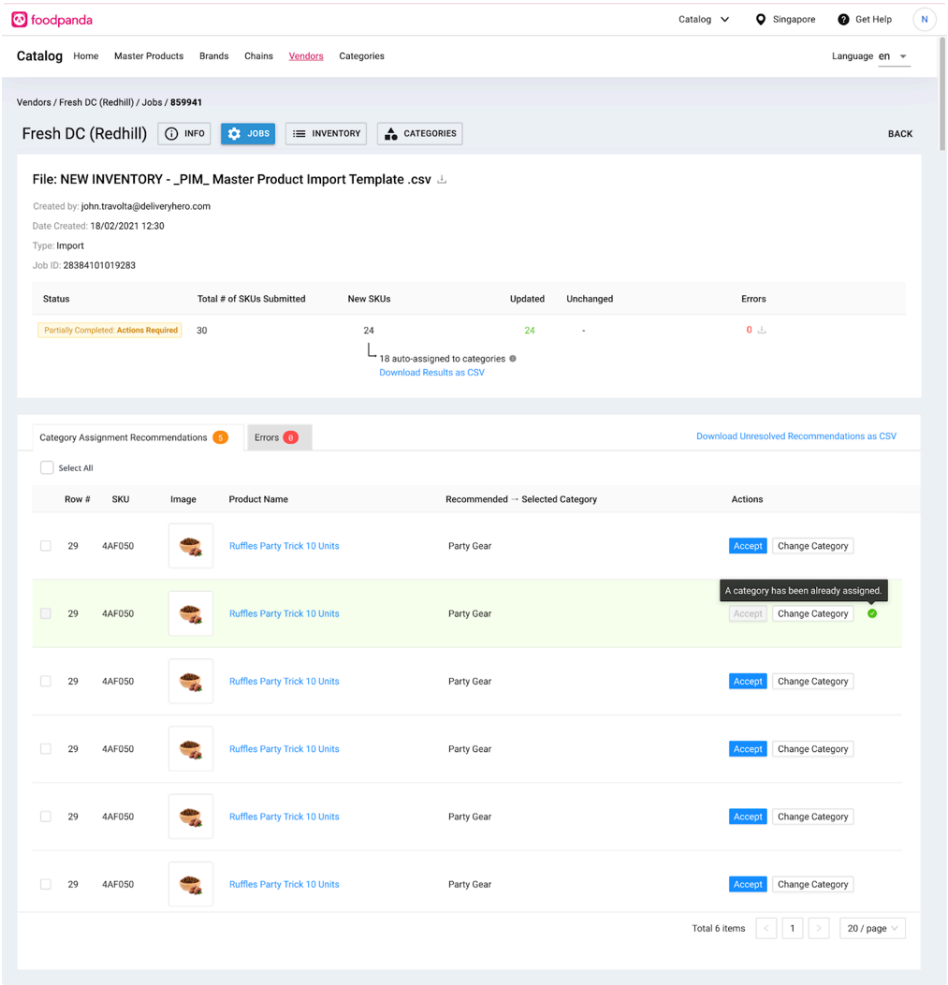

Image: Catalog UI with updates made in Figma

What This Means

This tiny test that Siddhant and Santi worked on unlocked something powerful. The idea that we can move faster, with less friction, and still maintain quality, even when resources are tight, is huge. AI has the potential to augment the relationship between design and other disciplines as it speeds up the ideation process **as an assistant but not as a replacement.**

We're still figuring out the best way to integrate AI-assisted flows into our development pipeline. But using AI to ideate, explore, and align is already proving to be a game-changer.

It's a reminder that "working smarter" isn't just a buzzword. With the right tools, we can focus our team's energy on the biggest, most valuable challenges—without dropping the smaller, incremental improvements that still matter.

And honestly? That's a future I'm excited to help build.

Have you considered giving AI a try to improve your workflows? If so, please share with me, and we can exchange our experiences.

Would you like to learn more about this specific test? Please reach out to @Guilherme Dias Simoes or @Siddhant Mittal on Slack. See you next time.